More than its frustration over the Soviet entry in Afghanistan, India feared the implications of the impending withdrawal. A botched departure could leave India out in the cold, while Pakistan and its Islamist proxies, who had Washington and Beijing's support, victorious in Afghanistan. Part of the aim of Indira Gandhi's visit to the US and the USSR in 1982 was to ensure a sustained dialogue between the two world powers and to seek a moderate political dispensation in Kabul after the Soviet retreat.[87] However, it was her younger son Rajiv Gandhi, who became PM on 31 October 1984 after his mother's assassination, whose 'balancing act' between Washington and Moscow in the latter half of 1980s brought India, somewhat, to the forefront in Afghanistan. Desperate to cut its losses, Moscow was looking for exit strategies from Afghanistan, and bent on making the invasion costly, Washington was looking for ways to undercut Soviet influence in South Asia. Reduction in Soviet influence in the region, however, meant the normalisation of India-Pakistan relations (and reducing India's military dependence on the Soviets). About three weeks before Gandhi was assassinated, on 11 October 1984, in a national security decision directive on 'U.S. policy towards India and Pakistan', Reagan pushed towards normalisation of ties between India and Pakistan.[88] Worried that a preemptive Indian strike on Pakistan's nuclear facilities in Kahuta may lead to an all-out war (those were the years when the Pakistan's nuclear facilities were still developing), the US was determined to engage with New Delhi regardless of Indian apprehensions about Washington's intentions.

In this context, Rajiv Gandhi's unexpected arrival as PM was a good omen for Washington and Moscow. To be clear, much like his mother, Rajiv's operational policy towards Afghanistan also had a covert edge with active involvement of the R&AW. Bent on undercutting Pakistan's influence, or as Zia called it, strategic depth, the R&AW with the KGB's support, continued to cultivate links with different Afghan groups (including the Mujahideen) as well as Pashtuns in Pakistan. The R&AW opened two separate desks, Counter Intelligence Team-X and Counter Intelligence Team-J, both of which were to wreak havoc in Pakistan and make its activities in Punjab 'prohibitively costly'.[89] The first team planted bombs across Pakistani cities, whereas the second team was focused on Khalistani groups. It was a 'tit-for-tat' model of covert warfare that India hoped would lead